what was a high-risk shot in his game. For me, the high risk would be if I *stopped* hooking.

Look at Matthew Hayden, Adam Gilchrist, Virender Sehwag – all of them attacking openers like me. You'll very seldom find that these guys play tentatively. Irrespective of whether it is a Test match or a one-day game, if they get 20 runs they are going to get them quickly, and if you are going to get them out, it will always be when they are trying to hit the ball.

That's always been my approach, too. Think about it … at its essence, cricket is a simple game of putting bat to ball. You can theorise all you want, but at the end of the day, you have to hit the bladdy ball if you want to win.

Obviously it's not all that simple. Occasions do arise when I should give myself more time to study the bowling and get in properly before attacking. Of course there have also been occasions when I have taken a liking to a particular bowler right from the start and proceeded to clock him to all corners of the park from ball one. There's no point in me scratching around the crease trying to follow orders to 'bat responsibly', because I just don't score runs. 'Being responsible' has let me down so many times – I think about things too much rather than just going out and bladdy well hitting the ball.

I am a far more effective player when I take on the bowling and dominate. I've learnt that the hard way, believe me. I know a lot of people think that my attitude is limiting and more than a little selfish, but the fact is, asking me to play conservative cricket is like asking me to play with one hand tied behind my back. Of course there have been times when I have had to keep an innings together as my colleagues have fallen around me, but even then you'll see my run rate has been atypically high for that kind of situation.

Duncan Fletcher has been the one coach who's always understood me. From my early days, when he coached me at Western Province in the 1990s through to his advisory role for the Proteas in 2009, Fletchie has always told me to 'go out and just play. I don't care what the situation is; you just play.' It's great to have someone who backs your game, and when I have that kind of confidence, irrespective of who the bowler is, they tend to travel. I have often played my best innings when I've thought, 'Hersch, you've got nothing to lose. Just go out there and hit the ball.' My innings in